

MIG-4

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-4

Age: 37

Gender: Male

Country of origin: Syria

Host country: Sweden

Years in host country: 7

Occupation: Restaurant Owner

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I escaped Syria seven years ago when the war destroyed my hometown of Aleppo, a city that had stood for thousands of years and was reduced, street by street, to rubble. My family home was bombed, and I lost several relatives to the conflict, people I had grown up with and loved. I journeyed through several countries over many months, facing real danger and profound uncertainty at every stage, before finally reaching Sweden, which granted me asylum. It was without question the hardest journey of my life, filled with moments where I did not know if I would survive to see the next day, moments where I paid strangers to smuggle me across borders and prayed they would not simply abandon me. Arriving safely felt almost unreal after everything.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being treated as a contributing member of society rather than as a refugee permanently dependent on aid and defined forever by the worst thing that ever happened to me. It shows itself when Swedes come to eat at my restaurant and genuinely appreciate Syrian cuisine and the culture behind it, when my children are given the same opportunities in school as their Swedish classmates, when I am spoken to as a business owner and a neighbour rather than as a case number or a problem to be managed. Belonging is being woven into the community's fabric rather than existing at its margins, always visible as an outsider. It is the point at which people stop seeing the refugee first and start seeing the man.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Yes, I have encountered xenophobia, and it intensified noticeably after various terrorist attacks across Europe, events that had nothing to do with me but for which I and others like me were made to feel collectively responsible. People would look at my beard with open suspicion, and on one occasion my restaurant window was vandalised with hateful graffiti telling foreigners to leave. That particular incident hurt more than I can easily express, because I fled the very extremism they seemed to fear I embodied; I am a victim of terror and violence, not a perpetrator of it. It is a bitter irony to escape fanaticism only to be treated as its representative by people who know nothing of what I have lost.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: Learning Swedish was incredibly difficult, both because it is a genuinely hard language for an Arabic speaker and because I was already carrying significant trauma from the war, which made concentration and memory much harder than they would otherwise have been. Rebuilding my entire life from nothing, without my former professional network, without my savings, without the social standing I had once had, was daunting in a way that is hard to convey to someone who has never lost everything at once. The bureaucracy of the asylum process and later of obtaining business permits tested my patience for years, with its endless forms and waiting and the constant sense that my future rested in the hands of officials who did not know me.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: As a business owner I now employ both Swedes and fellow migrants, and our workplace is genuinely harmonious, which is a source of real pride for me. My Swedish staff have taught me a great deal about local customs and expectations, correcting my mistakes gently, and in return I have shared my culture, my food, and my language with them. Food, I have found, brings people together across every kind of divide; my kitchen has become a small, working model of what integration can actually look like in practice, people of different backgrounds cooperating toward a shared goal and coming to respect one another in the process. The restaurant has given me not just a livelihood but a community.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I preserve my Syrian identity through my cooking above all, through my language, and through practising my faith quietly and privately in a country where religion is a much more personal matter than it was back home. My children speak Arabic and know their heritage, the poetry, the history, the traditions of the country they were too young to really remember. At the same time, I have sincerely embraced Swedish values of equality, of trust in institutions, and of a certain calm orderliness that I have come to appreciate. I feel Syrian in my soul, in the deepest part of who I am, but increasingly Swedish in my daily habits and my way of moving through the world, and I no longer see these as being in conflict.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: European media too often conflates refugees with terrorists, or else portrays us collectively as a burden weighing down the welfare system, draining resources that rightfully belong to others. This kind of coverage directly fuels the far-right and makes ordinary, decent people fearful of us before they have met a single refugee in person. I wish the media would show the other reality with equal prominence: the refugees who start businesses and create jobs, who pay their taxes faithfully, who volunteer, and who enrich Swedish society through hard work and a deep gratitude for the safety they have been given. The negative story is told endlessly; the positive one is barely told at all.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: The Swedish integration system provided language courses and startup support that were genuinely invaluable to me, and the establishment programme in particular helped me find my footing when I badly needed structure and guidance. I am grateful for what the system offered. That said, the process was often slow and could feel impersonal, treating every refugee as an interchangeable unit rather than

as an individual with particular skills, a particular history, and particular needs. More individualised support, the kind that actually recognises what a person was before they became a refugee and helps them rebuild toward it, would accelerate genuine integration considerably and would waste far less human potential in the process.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My children have adapted beautifully, more quickly and more completely than I have; they are fluent in Swedish, have local friends, and move through school life with an ease I sometimes envy. Occasionally I fear that they are forgetting Syria, that the country of their origin is becoming an abstraction to them rather than a living memory, but at the same time I am profoundly relieved that they do not carry the trauma that I carry, that they will not be haunted as I am by images of destruction and loss. They represent hope to me, a generation that can be fully and confidently Swedish while still honouring where their family came from, and I try every day to help them hold both of those things.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To combat xenophobia, communities need spaces where locals and migrants can interact naturally and repeatedly, whether through sports clubs, shared meals, community projects, or simply neighbourly proximity, because fear diminishes reliably through familiarity and contact. Politicians, for their part, must stop exploiting immigration as a wedge issue for votes, because that cynical strategy poisons the whole society. And success stories should be actively amplified so that people come to see refugees as neighbours, colleagues, and contributors rather than as an undifferentiated threat. In my own experience, every Swede who has come to know me as an individual, through my restaurant or otherwise, has let go of whatever suspicion they might once have held.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I dream of expanding my restaurant into a small chain that showcases Middle Eastern culture and hospitality across Sweden, employing more newcomers along the way and giving them the same chance I was given to build something. I hope, though I hardly dare to hope it, for eventual peace in Syria, so that I might one day visit my parents' graves and the ruins of the city I loved. But most of all, and most concretely, I want my children to have the stable, prosperous, and peaceful life that the war so cruelly denied me, to grow up without fear and to achieve things I could only have dreamed of at their age.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice is to learn the language no matter how impossibly hard it feels at the start, because it is the key that unlocks absolutely everything else, work, friendship, dignity, and belonging. Be patient, because genuine integration takes years and not months, and there will be many discouraging moments along the way. Contribute to your community in whatever way you can, however small, and let your work and your conduct speak for you when words fail or are misunderstood. And, perhaps most importantly of all, never let the hatred you may encounter harden your own heart or make you bitter, because bitterness will only imprison you further and rob you of the future you crossed so much to reach.